



Into thin air

Like everything else, air is pulled by gravity. Most air molecules are pulled close to the ground, where the air is thick and easy to breathe. Higher up, air is so thin that climbers need oxygen tanks.

Layers of the atmosphere
The atmosphere is made up of layers, each with a different name. The bottom layer is the troposphere, where clouds form and planes fly. Above this, the air gets thinner and thinner as the atmosphere merges into space.

Light spectacular

Sunlight can create dazzling effects as it strikes the atmosphere and is scattered by air, water, and dust.



Rainbows form when water droplets reflect sunlight and split it into different colours.



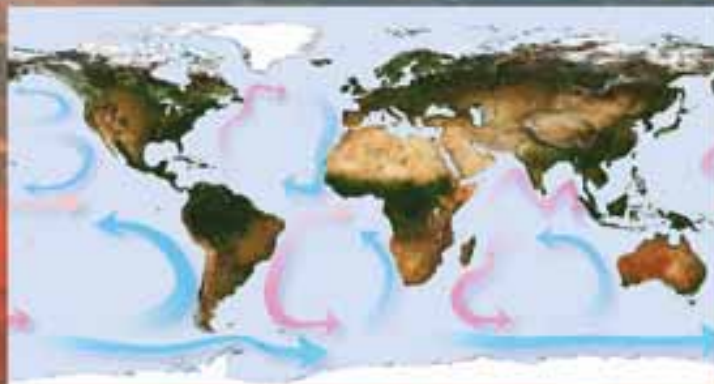
The sky looks blue on clear days because air molecules scatter blue light the most.



At sunset and sunrise, dust and hazy cloud in the air turn the sky orange and red.

Moving water

The atmosphere is always swirling around, creating winds. The winds push on the oceans, causing the water to swirl too. These swirling currents carry warmth around the planet.



THERMOSPHERE



Satellite



Space shuttle

Northern lights



MESOSPHERE



85 km (53 miles)
Shooting stars

STRATOSPHERE



50 km (31 miles)

Weather balloon

TROPOSPHERE



10 km (6 miles)

Jumbo jet